Washington followed this debate closely. Other countries, including American allies like Britain, had made clear that they would soon recognize the communist Chinese government. But US policymakers and legislators watched India's decision closely because Nehru was thought to have broader influence, especially among other developing countries and with the Commonwealth.[90] Chairman Tom Connally's first question to Acheson at a Senate Foreign Relations Committee hearing ahead of the Indian prime minister's visit to Washington had been whether India was favoring recognition.[91]

Administration officials were aware that Nehru's government was leaning toward recognition. In May 1949, the US ambassador to China had conveyed rumors that India would recognize the communist government "fairly promptly after [a] 'decent interval.'"[92] American officials had subsequently sought assurances from the Indian government that it would coordinate or at least consult with the US or Commonwealth states on the matter of recognition.[93] By September, it had been evident that it was just a matter of time before India recognized Mao's regime.[94] In Delhi, the Indian foreign secretary had remarked to the US chargé that, while there was "no reason for haste," recognition was "inevitable."[95]

Nehru had not decided on the how and when of recognition on the eve of his visit to the US.[96] In public in the US, he avoided direct answers but made clear that recognition was in the offing.[97] The prime minister subscribed to scholar-diplomat Panikkar's view that recognition would put India in a "better position to protect [its] interests" vis-à-vis China than isolating it.[98] He wanted to discuss Indian interests in Tibet, which Chinese premier Zhou Enlai had told Panikkar would be safeguarded, and the India-Tibet boundary with Chinese officials.[99] Moreover, he believed that indefinite delay or conditional recognition would likely push China and the Soviet Union together and strengthen the hands of those in Beijing pushing for such a communist alliance.[100] Bajpai outlined another reason to Henderson: India's role in Asia would be adversely affected if other Asian countries recognized China and Delhi did not.[101]

Patel would later tell the American ambassador that Nehru's decision was also hurried along by indications that Britain and the US were just waiting for a good time to recognize China. Nehru wanted to pre-empt them so that Beijing would see him as a leader rather than a follower.[102] The